

THE FIGHT for liberty

THE AGE OF REVOLUTION

The period between 1775–1848 in Europe and the Americas is often called the Age of Revolution by historians. During these tumultuous years, many nations experienced social and political movements that led to major domestic conflict; other nations were dragged into international warfare. The two most famous revolutions occurred in North America and in France, both inspired by the Enlightenment—an ideological movement that promoted liberty and freedom. Caught up in the revolutionary atmosphere, many women saw the changing times as a chance to better the lives of their sex.

Fighting for freedom

Early revolutionary efforts in North America relied on the cooperation of women, especially for the boycott of British goods. For example, in 1774, the women of Edenton, North Carolina, refused to buy British products until its Parliament repealed the punitive legislation that restricted trade by the colonists. Once armed hostilities began to rage between the

Patriots and Loyalists, women also joined the military effort in a variety of capacities. Some became camp followers, traveling with the armies as wives, laundry women, or prostitutes; others carried messages. Famously, in 1777, a 16-year-old girl called Sybil Ludington rode 40 miles (65 km) to warn the colonists about an imminent British raid on Danbury, Connecticut. In South Carolina,

◀ Lady Liberty

This banner of Lady Liberty was likely made by women to carry at a Philadelphia public parade in the 1790s. Her liberty pole and Phrygian cap are both symbols of revolution.

